

JAMES D. RODGERS

Instructional Designer · Generative AI Specialist

San Francisco, CA · 614-364-1120 · jdevin.rodgers@gmail.com · [linkedin.com/in/jdevinrodgers](https://www.linkedin.com/in/jdevinrodgers) · www.jamesdrodgers.ai

SUMMARY

Instructional designer and learning systems strategist with 15 years of experience designing learning systems that align training, performance, and organizational goals. Brings firsthand AI expertise including direct contributions to Grok 2 and 3 at xAI and certification in AI application design from Purdue University. Specializes in designing learning experiences that increase buy-in around mission and vision while improving knowledge retention, staff performance, and operational outcomes.

SKILLS

Design Learning systems architecture · Organizational needs & performance gap analysis · Backward design (Understanding by Design) · Competency-based curriculum design · Universal Design for Learning (UDL) · Equity-centered instructional design

Technology AI-augmented learning design · Prompt engineering · LLM fine-tuning · Data analytics & visualization · LMS & LTI integration · Canvas · Moodle · Google Classroom · Jupyter · OpenAI API · Python

Impact Strategic planning & program development · Instructional coaching · Standards-based formative/summative evaluation · Data-driven decision-making

WORK EXPERIENCE

Aquatics Safety and Training — YMCA San Francisco *San Francisco, CA · April 2025 – Present*

- Improved branch safety audit scores from 78% to 92% through multimedia, AI-augmented continuing education content covering water rescue, CPR, and oxygen administration.
- Backward-designed and facilitated monthly in-service trainings for 15 lifeguard staff, grounding each session in incident data and YMCA safety standards and reinforcing learning between sessions through weekly skill-focused content.
- Used performance data analytics to identify individual skill gaps, design training programs, and deliver targeted on-deck instruction for 130 youth and adult swimmers.

Human Data AI Tutor — xAI *San Francisco, CA · April 2024 – April 2025*

- Applied pedagogical methods to refine model outputs and close reasoning gaps across audio, text, and visual modalities, contributing directly to the release of Grok 2 and 3.
- Designed AI foundational training content for 50+ cross-disciplinary team members, translating complex technical concepts into accessible resources adopted into the Team Lead Resource Library.
- Collaborated with team and project leads to iteratively design workflows and develop AI architecture and content knowledge training for 200+ annotators and team leads, sustaining 90%+ QA performance scores.

Lead Pastor — The Episcopal Church *Bexley, OH and San Francisco, CA · January 2017 – October 2023*

- Architected a custom GPT for the Episcopal Diocese of Ohio, transforming congregational attendance, demographic, and financial data across 85 congregations into a tool for learning and discernment that equipped diocesan leadership with

planning intelligence for strategic resource allocation and mission development, serving 10,000 members and \$20 million in annual operating revenue.

- Conducted organizational needs analysis and developed a five-year strategic plan, mobilizing \$500,000 for a capital building project and closing a \$50,000 budget gap within a \$375,000 operating budget.
- Identified and convened a nine-person cross-functional team of congregational stakeholders to co-design organizational vision, core values, and mission framework, establishing the institutional foundation that drove 5% annual growth in membership, individual giving, and revenue over four years through strategic alignment with national and diocesan educational resources.
- Sustained parish cohesion, identity, and programming through two years of restricted in-person worship by pivoting to digital education, earning a 90% approval rating from a 400-member congregation.

Music Educator and Instructional Designer — North College Hill MS/HS*Cincinnati, OH · June 2010 – January 2014*

- Rebuilt a band program from 30 to 75 students in three years through equity-centered, culturally responsive curriculum design, removing participation barriers in a school community where over 90% of students qualified for free or reduced lunch by securing instruments through grant writing, community partnerships, and donation drives for 60% of participants.
- Collaborated with boosters, parents, civic organizations, and school administration to restructure scheduling so students no longer had to choose between academic intervention and music, expanding access to roughly one quarter of the student population.
- Designed and facilitated ongoing project-based STEAM professional development for 40 faculty and mentored 3 student teachers, modeling equity-centered design, data-informed instruction, and UDL-based engagement techniques.

PORTFOLIO PROJECTS

- [Pulmonary Artery Catheterization | Clinical Instructional Design Sample](#) Canvas-based clinical module developed with a subject matter expert applying Bloom's Taxonomy, backward design, and multimodal content strategies to teach PAC interpretation and hemodynamics to nursing students. Includes a custom AI tutor and case-based assessments demonstrating applied learning tool architecture and LMS design in a high-stakes clinical context.
- [Intro to Python Programming | Module 1 Instructional Design Sample](#) Complete Canvas module for first-year undergraduate learners using backward design, UDL frameworks, and DEIJ-informed learner personas. Integrated AI-adaptive assessment via LTI, Jupyter Notebook guided practice, and a competency-based capstone project aligned to six measurable learning objectives. Built for multilingual and culturally diverse learners in an asynchronous environment.
- [YMCA Aquatics Continuing Education and Coaching Analytics](#) Multimedia instructional content and data-driven coaching tools including continuing education slide decks, safety infographics, longitudinal performance analytics, and individualized progress reports benchmarked against national standards. Demonstrates applied learning analytics, multimodal content design, and competency-based instructional coaching.

EDUCATION & CERTIFICATIONS

Purdue University · Certificate in Generative AI Applications · 2025

City College of San Francisco · Certificate in Data Analytics · In Progress

Graduate Theological Union : Church Divinity School of the Pacific · Master of Divinity · 2017 · Berkeley, CA

Teach for America · Corps Member · Jacksonville, FL · 2009–2010

Miami University · Bachelor of Music Education, Minor in Special Education · Oxford, OH